temple, and will be 900 metres long. With 80 per cent of the land acquired, work on it is expected to be over by October 2023. Finally, there will be the Ram *path*, which will connect the Sahadatganj area in Ayodhya district to the Naya Ghat of Ayodhya town. The longest of the three *path*s, the 12.9 km four-lane road will be the link between Ayodhya town and the rest of the district, and will make entrance to Ayodhya easy from the old Faizabad city, 7 km away.

To visit the temple without entering Ayodhya city, a Rs 500 crore, 67 km-long ring road project has been envisaged. It will connect Ayodhya to Basti, a town around 70 km away, and also go via Gonda, a town 50 km away, skirting 37 villages along the way. Bypassing Ayodhya city will save at least 30 minutes on the journey. Land acquisition is expected to be done by January 2023, and construction is likely to take two and a half years.

Meanwhile, those interested in sailing down the Sarayu will have a state-of-the-art solar-powered, double-decker luxury cruise ship later this year courtesy of the Ramayana Cruise Service. To be handled by a private player, the district administration's role will be limited to facilitating the basic requirements for this project. Pilgrims and tourists will be able to avail of the service to go from Naya Ghat to Guptar Ghat.

The Naya Ghat crossing itself, a focal point of the city, has been renamed the Lata Mangeshkar Smriti Chowk, in memory of the Bharat Ratna, who passed away on February 6 this year. Master sculptor Ram Vanji Sutar, who has designed the 'Statue of Unity' in Gujarat, has made a 40 foot-long, 24 tonne veena to be placed at the crossing, which reached Ayodhya from Noida on September 15. Famous Lata bhajans will be played at the crossing. The total budget for the project? Rs 7.9 crore.

Multi-storeyed parking spots and four shopping complexes are also expected to be ready before September 23. The shopping complexes will come up in Tedhi Bazar 1, Tedhi Bazar 2, Kaushlesh Kunj and Amani Ganj. The tentative budget for this project is Rs 100 crore.

They are meant to rehabilitate Ayodhya's traders and shopkeepers who have lost business owing to the new constructions. It has been somewhat of a contentious issue—last year, several traders and shopkeepers petitioned the trust, asking for their shops not to be demolished for the proposed widening of roads leading up to the temple. Traders from 12 local markets marched to the temple to hand over their petition to the priest for it to be placed at the deity's feet.

THE MOSQUE IS STUCK AS THE FIRE DEPARTMENT HAS DENIED AN NOC IN THE ABSENCE OF A 12 METRE-WIDE APPROACH ROAD

Last September, the Lucknow bench of the Allahabad High Court disposed of a writ petition seeking a directive to the state government to rehabilitate the shopkeepers of Hanumangarhi Road before demolishing their establishments for the road widening project. "We are serious about their concerns. We are planning to either give them compensation or shift their shops to the new complexes," says the DM.

WHAT OF THE MOSQUE?

Last year, the UP government had allocated five acres of land to the Uttar Pradesh Sunni Central Waqf Board for a mosque as directed in the Supreme Court verdict on Ayodhya. The Waqf Board, in turn, established a trust, the Indo-Islamic Cultural Foundation (IICF), this February, which handed over the responsibility of designing the mosque to M. Akhtar, a renowned architect and dean of the architecture department at Delhi's Jamia Millia Islamia University. The masjid complex will also house a 300-bed charitable hospital, a museum archive and a public library.

However, the fate of the mosque now hangs in balance. The fire department recently denied the trust a no-objection certificate in the absence of a 12 metre-wide approach road. "Due to the narrow width of the approach road, the fire department did not issue an NOC," R.K. Rai, the chief fire officer of Ayodhya, said in a statement. "We have written a letter to the Indo-Islamic Cultural Foundation."

According to Athar Husain, secretary of the IICF, the foundation has already written to the state government, demanding the construction of a 12 metre-wide road at the earliest. "We happily accepted the land that we got from the government. The government and officials should now help us in solving the issue," says Husain. The Ayodhya district administration has formed a committee to resolve the issue. "We have also asked the fire department team to revisit the area and get an update," says DM Kumar.

Even as Ayodhya races towards the grand Ram temple that the Hindu right had ferociously wished for, a concession to the city's Muslims could act as a balm that can soothe the wounds of communal disharmony. ■